

EMAIL MANAGEMENT

Standard Operating Procedure

For Solo Small~Medium Service Business Owners

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PURPOSE:

This document outlines the daily email management process for a solo service business owner. It is designed to give a VA clear, repeatable instructions for managing the owner's inbox with minimal supervision. The goal is to protect the owner's time, ensure no lead or client is missed, and keep the inbox organized and actionable at all times.

SCOPE:

This SOP covers Gmail inbox management for a solo service business owner. It applies to all inbound client communication, lead inquiries, booking coordination, and general admin emails. It does not cover social media DMs, invoicing platforms, or project management tools unless those communications are forwarded to the inbox.

1. INBOX STRUCTURE

Overview

Before any daily routines begin, the inbox must be structured correctly. A well-organized Gmail inbox is the foundation of everything in this SOP. Without it, triage becomes guesswork and things get missed.

This section covers the label system, color coding logic, and the rules for what gets starred, archived, or deleted.

1.1 Label System

Gmail labels function as folders, but with one key difference: a single email can carry multiple labels. This flexibility is intentional. Use it.

Create the following labels in Gmail under Settings → Labels → Create New Label:

LEADS

For any first-contact inquiry from a potential client. This includes contact form submissions forwarded to the inbox, cold inquiries, referral introductions, and anyone who has expressed interest but has not yet booked or paid.

BOOKED

For confirmed clients who have signed a contract or paid a deposit. Once a lead becomes a client, their thread moves from LEADS to BOOKED. These are active relationships.

PENDING

For threads that are waiting on something — a response from the client, a payment, a document, a decision. If an email cannot be resolved yet, it lives here until it can be acted on.

URGENT

For anything that requires the owner's attention or action within 24 hours. This label is not for general priority — it is specifically for items that cannot wait and must be escalated. Use it sparingly. If everything is urgent, nothing is.

ARCHIVE – [MONTH YEAR]

For threads that are fully resolved and no longer need active attention. Create a new archive label each month. Example: ARCHIVE – MAY 2026. This keeps old threads accessible without cluttering the active inbox.

Optional supporting labels (add if the business requires them):

VENDORS

for supplier, software, or service provider communication

ADMIN

for receipts, subscriptions, platform notifications, and non-client business emails

REFERRALS

if the owner tracks referral sources and wants to separate those threads

1.2 Color Coding Logic

Assign colors to labels so the inbox is scannable at a glance without reading every subject line. Use Gmail's built-in label color system.

Recommended color assignments:

LEADS – Blue. Opportunity. Needs attention.

BOOKED – Green. Active client. Healthy and in motion.

PENDING – Yellow/Orange. Waiting. Flagged but not resolved.

URGENT – Red. Immediate. Cannot be ignored.

ARCHIVE – Grey. Closed. No action needed.

The logic behind this system is traffic light thinking: green means go, yellow means wait, red means stop and address now. Blue is a new potential. Grey is done. Adjust colors to the owner's preference, but maintain the intent behind each color category.

1.3 Starring Logic

Stars in Gmail are a secondary layer of flagging. In this system, stars serve one specific purpose: marking threads that require a follow-up action from the VA.

Star a thread when: — A response has been sent and you are waiting for a reply that must be followed up on if no response comes within 48 hours — An action is due on a specific date and you need a visible reminder in the inbox — The owner has asked you to monitor a particular thread

Do not star threads simply because they are important. URGENT label handles priority escalation. Stars are for follow-up tracking only.

Clear stars once the follow-up has been completed or the thread has been resolved.

1.4 Archive and Delete Rules

The inbox should only contain threads that are active or pending action. Everything else should be labeled and archived, or deleted outright.

Archive a thread when:

- The conversation is fully resolved with no outstanding actions
- A lead has gone cold after the standard follow-up sequence has been completed
- The email is informational and has been read and noted
- A booking has been completed and all deliverables have been sent

Delete a thread when:

- It is confirmed spam
- It is a newsletter, promotional email, or automated notification with no business relevance
- It is a duplicate thread or a one-word acknowledgment reply that adds no information

Do not delete anything that could be referenced later:

- client conversations, contracts, payment confirmations, or complaints. When in doubt, archive, not delete.

1.5 Initial Setup Checklist

Before operating this system on a new inbox, complete the following setup steps:

1. Create all labels listed in Section 1.1 inside the owner's Gmail account.
 2. Assign colors to each label as outlined in Section 1.2.
 3. Turn off Gmail's default tabs (Promotions, Social, Updates) or configure them according to the owner's preference. All client emails should land in Primary.
 4. Enable keyboard shortcuts in Gmail Settings for faster triage.
 5. Confirm with the owner which senders should always be marked as Priority or starred by default.
 6. Review the existing inbox and apply labels retroactively to any active threads before beginning the daily routine.
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2. DAILY INBOX ROUTINE

Overview

A structured daily routine is what separates inbox management from inbox monitoring. Monitoring is passive — you check and react. Management is active — you triage, decide, and move things forward. This section defines the exact routine the VA follows every working day, including what to look for, how to prioritize, and what the end-of-day standard looks like.

This routine assumes the inbox structure from Section 1 is already in place.

2.1 Morning Check

Time: First task of the working day, before anything else.

The morning check is a triage session, not a response session. The goal is to assess what came in, assign it to the right label, and identify anything that needs to move immediately.

Work through the inbox in this order:

1. Scan for anything flagged URGENT from the previous day that is still unresolved. Address these first before processing anything new.
2. Read every new unread email from top to bottom. Do not skip threads. Do not leave emails marked as unread unless you are intentionally flagging them for later.
3. Apply labels immediately as you read. Do not batch label at the end — label as you go so the inbox stays organized throughout the session.
4. Identify any thread that requires the owner's attention and flag it using the escalation process outlined in Section 4.
5. Draft or send responses where the action is clear and within your scope. Hold anything that requires owner input until escalation is confirmed.
6. Star any thread where a follow-up will be needed within 48 hours.

The morning check should take no longer than 20 to 30 minutes on a normal volume day. If it consistently takes longer, the inbox structure or response process needs to be reviewed.

2.2 Priority Triage

Not all emails carry equal weight. During triage, every email falls into one of three categories:

Act Now — Respond or escalate within the same working day. This includes new lead inquiries, client questions about an active booking, payment issues, and anything the owner has flagged as time-sensitive. Apply URGENT if owner action is needed.

Act Soon — Respond within 48 hours. This includes general client questions, non-urgent follow-ups, and vendor or admin communication. Apply **PENDING** and star if a follow-up will be needed.

No Action Required — Read, note if relevant, label, and archive. This includes newsletters the owner has chosen to keep, automated platform notifications, and resolved threads with a final reply that needs no response.

When in doubt between Act Now and Act Soon, default to Act Now. It is better to over-prioritize than to miss something time-sensitive.

2.3 Response Time Standards

The following response time standards apply unless the owner specifies otherwise:

New lead inquiries — Same day, within business hours. A lead that does not hear back within 24 hours is a lead at risk of going elsewhere.

Active client questions — Within 24 hours.

Pending items waiting on the client — Follow up after 48 hours of no response. A second follow-up goes out after 72 hours if still no reply.

General admin and vendor emails — Within 48 hours unless time-sensitive.

Spam, promotions, irrelevant emails — Delete or archive same day. Do not let these accumulate.

Response time standards apply to business days only. If the owner does not operate on weekends, adjust the clock accordingly and confirm this with the owner during onboarding.

2.4 End of Day Check

Time: Last task of the working day.

The end of day check is shorter than the morning check. Its purpose is to catch anything that came in during the day, confirm the inbox is in order, and close the day cleanly.

Work through the following:

1. Process any new emails that arrived after the morning check. Apply the same triage logic from Section 2.2.
2. Review all starred threads. Has anything been sitting for more than 48 hours without a response from the client? If yes, prepare a follow-up for the next morning or send it now if within business hours.
3. Check the PENDING label. Has anything been resolved during the day that can now be archived? Clear it if yes.
4. Confirm the URGENT label is empty or that all urgent items have been escalated and acknowledged by the owner.

5. Aim for inbox zero in the Primary tab. Every email should be labeled and either archived, pending, or actively being handled. Nothing should sit unlabeled in the inbox overnight.

Inbox zero is not about deleting everything. It is about having a clear answer for every thread: it is either resolved and archived, pending with a plan, or escalated and waiting on the owner. No orphaned emails.

3. RESPONSE GUIDELINES

Overview

Every email sent from the owner's inbox is a representation of their brand. Tone, speed, and clarity all signal professionalism to clients and leads. This section defines the voice standards the VA follows when drafting responses, and provides templates for the most common email scenarios. Templates are starting points, not scripts — they must be adjusted to fit the specific context of each thread before sending.

A Note on Existing Workflows

Many solo service business owners already have automated email sequences, CRM-triggered responses, or templated workflows set up through tools like HoneyBook, Dubsado, or similar platforms. If that is the case, the templates in Section 3.2 are not meant to replace those systems.

Use this section as a reference for situations that fall outside automated workflows — one-off client questions, edge cases, manual follow-ups, or moments where a personal response is more appropriate than an automated one. When in doubt, check with the owner before sending any reply that may duplicate or conflict with an existing sequence.

3.1 Tone and Voice Standards

The following standards apply to all outbound emails regardless of the recipient:

Warm but professional

Emails should feel like they are coming from a real person who is competent and approachable, not from a corporate auto-responder. Avoid stiff, formal language. Avoid being overly casual.

Clear and direct

Say what needs to be said in as few sentences as possible. Do not pad emails with unnecessary context or filler phrases. Clients and leads are busy. Respect their time.

Personalized

Use the recipient's first name. Reference something specific from their inquiry or their booking where relevant. Generic emails are easy to ignore.

Confident but not pushy

When following up on a lead or a payment, the tone should be helpful and matter-of-fact, not apologetic or aggressive.

Owner's voice

Before sending any email for the first time, confirm with the owner how they typically communicate – whether they use contractions, how formal their sign-off is, whether they use humor. Match that voice consistently. The client should never feel like they are suddenly talking to a different person.

Things to avoid in all emails:

- Phrases like "I hope this email finds you well" or "Just following up" – these are filler and weaken the opening
- Overly long paragraphs – break text into short blocks for readability
- Vague sign-offs like "Let me know if you have questions" without a clear next step
- Sending a response without re-reading it once for tone and accuracy

3.2 Response Templates

The following templates are written for a solo service business owner in a client-facing industry. Adjust the bracketed fields to match the owner's business, service, and voice before use. Do not copy and paste without personalizing.

Template 1 – New Lead Inquiry

Use when: A potential client contacts the owner for the first time asking about services, availability, or pricing.

Subject: Re: [Original Subject Line]

Hi [First Name],

Thanks for reaching out – [Owner's Name] would love to connect with you about [service or event type].

To make sure we can give you the most accurate information, could you share a few quick details:

– What date are you looking at? – Where will [the event / project / session] be held? – Anything specific you are hoping for that we should know upfront?

Once we have those details, we will follow up with availability and next steps.

Looking forward to hearing from you.

[Owner's Name] [Business Name] [Contact or booking link if applicable]

Template 2 – Booking Confirmation

Use when: A client has paid a deposit or signed a contract and the booking is now confirmed.

Subject: You're Booked – [Date or Project Name]

Hi [First Name],

Exciting news — you are officially locked in. Here is a quick summary of what we have confirmed:

Date: [Date] Service: [Service Type] Location: [Location if applicable] Next step: [What happens next — e.g. questionnaire, planning call, delivery timeline]

If anything changes on your end or you have questions in the meantime, just reply to this email and we will get back to you promptly.

Looking forward to working with you.

[Owner's Name] [Business Name]

Template 3 — Payment Follow-Up

Use when: A payment due date has passed and no payment has been received. Use after the first missed deadline. Adjust for second follow-up if needed.

Subject: Quick Note — [Invoice or Payment Reference]

Hi [First Name],

Just a quick note to flag that we have not yet received the [deposit / final payment / balance] for your [booking / project] on [date].

If everything is in order on your end and it has simply slipped through, no problem at all — here are the payment details again:

[Payment method or link] Amount due: [Amount] Due date: [Original due date]

If you have any questions about the invoice or need to make alternate arrangements, just let us know and we can sort it out.

[Owner's Name] [Business Name]

Template 4 — General Client Question

Use when: An active client asks a question about their booking, timeline, deliverables, or process that falls within standard scope and does not require owner input.

Subject: Re: [Original Subject Line]

Hi [First Name],

Great question. Here is what you need to know:

[Answer the question directly in two to four sentences. Be specific. If there are multiple parts to the question, use a short list.]

If there is anything else you are unsure about, feel free to reply here and we will get back to you.

[Owner's Name] [Business Name]

Template 5 – Cold Lead Follow-Up

Use when: A lead made an inquiry but did not respond to the initial reply. Send this after 48 to 72 hours of silence.

Subject: Re: [Original Subject Line]

Hi [First Name],

Just circling back on your inquiry in case it got buried. We are still happy to help if you are still exploring options for [service or event type].

If your plans have changed, no worries at all – just let us know and we will close this out on our end.

[Owner's Name] [Business Name]

3.2 Response Templates

Run through this checklist before sending any email drafted from a template:

- ☒ Have you replaced every bracketed field with real, accurate information?
- ☒ Does the tone match the owner's voice as established during onboarding?
- ☒ Is the email clear enough that the recipient knows exactly what to do next?
- ☒ If this email requires owner review before sending, has it been approved?
- ☒ Is the subject line accurate and relevant to the thread?

If the answer to any of these is no, do not send. Fix it first.

4. ESCALATION RULES

Overview

One of the most valuable things a VA can do is make the right call about what to handle independently and what to bring to the owner. Over-escalating wastes the owner's time. Under-escalating creates risk. This section defines exactly where that line is, how to flag items that cross it, and how to document escalations so nothing falls through the cracks.

4.1 Handle Independently

The following types of emails can be responded to or actioned without owner input, provided the response falls within the templates and guidelines in Section 3:

- New lead inquiries that only require collecting basic information from the prospective client before passing to the owner
- Booking confirmations where the contract is signed and payment is received and the next step is clearly defined
- General client questions about timeline, process, or deliverables that are already documented or have been answered by the owner before
- Payment follow-ups using the standard template where the invoice details are confirmed and accurate
- Cold lead follow-ups after 48 to 72 hours of no response
- Archiving and inbox maintenance tasks
- Automated notification emails from platforms the owner uses – read, note if relevant, archive
- Spam and promotional emails – delete or archive without escalation

The guiding principle: if the situation is routine, the answer is already known, and the response carries no risk of miscommunication or financial impact, handle it.

4.2 Escalate to the Owner

The following situations require the owner's awareness or direct input before any response is sent:

- A lead is asking for custom pricing, packages, or anything outside the standard offer
 - A client is expressing dissatisfaction, frustration, or a formal complaint of any kind
 - A client is requesting a refund, cancellation, or significant change to a confirmed booking
 - A legal, contractual, or liability-related question has been raised
 - A media outlet, agency, or partnership inquiry has come in
 - Payment has been disputed or a chargeback has been initiated
 - An email has arrived from someone the VA does not recognize whose relationship to the business is unclear
 - A situation has come up that has no clear precedent in this SOP or in prior owner instructions
 - The VA is unsure. When in doubt, escalate. It is always better to ask than to act on an assumption.
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4.3 How to Escalate

When an email needs to be escalated, follow this process:

Step 1 – Apply the URGENT label to the thread immediately.

Step 2 – Do not leave the client or lead waiting without acknowledgement. If a response is needed while waiting for the owner, send a brief holding reply using this format:

Hi [First Name],

Thanks for getting in touch. I have flagged this for [Owner's Name] and they will be in touch with you directly within [timeframe – e.g. 24 hours / one business day].

Appreciate your patience.

[Owner's Name] [Business Name]

Step 3 – Notify the owner through the agreed escalation channel. This should be confirmed during onboarding. Common options:

- A direct message via WhatsApp, Slack, or the owner's preferred messaging app
- A flagged task in the project management tool if one is in use
- A forwarded email to a separate internal address if the owner prefers email-based escalation

Step 4 – In the escalation notification, include the following:

- Who sent the email and their relationship to the business (lead, active client, vendor, unknown)
- A one to two sentence summary of what the email is about
- Why you are escalating – what specifically is outside your scope
- Whether a holding reply has already been sent
- A link to or copy of the original thread

Step 5 – Log the escalation in the weekly report as outlined in Section 5.

4.4 Escalation Response Time Expectations

Once an escalation has been flagged, the owner is expected to respond to the VA within the timeframe agreed during onboarding. The VA is responsible for following up with the owner if no response is received before the holding reply window expires.

If the owner is unreachable and a time-sensitive client situation requires an immediate response, the VA should send a second holding reply extending the timeframe and make one additional attempt to reach the owner through an alternate channel. Do not attempt to resolve an escalated situation independently.

5. WEEKLY MAINTENANCE

Overview

Daily inbox management keeps things moving. Weekly maintenance keeps the system healthy. This section covers the three responsibilities the VA carries out once a week: the inbox audit, the template review, and the owner report. These tasks are not optional – they are what prevent small issues from compounding into bigger ones and what keep the owner informed without requiring them to check in constantly.

5.1 Inbox Audit

Conduct the inbox audit once per week, ideally on the same day each week. Friday works well for most businesses as it closes the week cleanly, but confirms the preferred day with the owner during onboarding.

Work through the following:

Step 1 – Review the LEADS label. Identify any lead that has been sitting without a response or follow-up for more than 72 hours. Either send a follow-up using Template 5 from Section 3.2 or flag it for the owner if the lead requires a custom response.

Step 2 – Review the PENDING label. Identify any thread that has been sitting in PENDING for more than five business days. Determine whether a follow-up is needed, whether the item can be closed and archived, or whether it needs to be escalated.

Step 3 – Review all starred threads. Confirm that every star still has a reason to be there. Remove stars from threads that have been resolved. Add stars to any thread that slipped through during the week without a follow-up flag.

Step 4 – Review the URGENT label. It should be empty by end of week. If anything is still sitting there, investigate why it has not been resolved and escalate again if necessary.

Step 5 – Review the current month's ARCHIVE label. Spot-check a sample of archived threads to confirm that nothing was archived prematurely – meaning a thread was closed before it was actually resolved.

Step 6 – Check for any emails sitting unlabeled in the Primary inbox. These should not exist if the daily routine is being followed correctly, but the audit is the safety net. Label and process anything found.

Step 7 – Unsubscribe from any recurring promotional or newsletter emails that have no business relevance and continue to clutter the inbox. Do not unsubscribe from anything that may be business-relevant without confirming with the owner first.

5.2 Template Review

Once per month – or sooner if a gap becomes apparent – review the response templates in Section 3.2 against real situations that came up during the week.

Ask the following:

- Did any email come in this week that the existing templates did not cover well? If yes, draft a new template and flag it for the owner's approval before adding it to the SOP.
- Did any template produce a response that felt off – wrong tone, wrong information, wrong length? If yes, note what the issue was and propose a revision.
- Has the owner updated their pricing, packages, process, or policies in a way that makes any existing template inaccurate? If yes, update the template immediately and log the change in the version history of this document.
- Templates should reflect how the business actually communicates right now, not how it communicated when this SOP was first written. Treat them as living documents.

5.3 Weekly Report to Owner

Send a brief weekly report to the owner every Friday, or on the last working day of the week. The report should take no more than five minutes to read. Its purpose is to give the owner full visibility into inbox activity without requiring them to log in and check themselves.

The report covers the following:

Inbox Summary

- Total emails received this week
- Total emails responded to independently

- Total emails escalated to owner
- Any threads still open and why

Lead Activity

- Number of new lead inquiries received
- Status of each lead – responded, pending reply, followed up, gone cold
- Any leads that converted to bookings this week

Escalations Log

- List of all escalated items from the week
- Current status of each – resolved, pending owner response, still open
- Any escalation that has not yet been acknowledged by the owner

Flags for Next Week

- Upcoming follow-ups that are due in the next five business days
- Any client whose booking date is approaching and may require proactive communication
- Any pattern or recurring issue the VA has noticed that the owner should be aware of

Template or SOP Updates

- Note any changes made to templates this week
- Flag any situation that exposed a gap in the SOP and may require a new guideline

Keep the report in a consistent format every week. Use the same structure so the owner can scan it quickly without having to read it in full every time. Deliver it via the communication channel agreed during onboarding.

